

Audio Technica ATH-M50xBT2

A successor that proves its mettle!

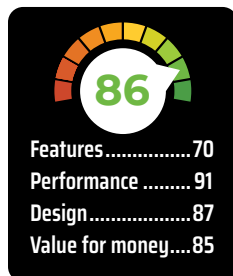
We tested the Audio Technica ATH-M50xBT back in 2019, with the latest device from the lineup tested by us being the Audio Technica ATH-M20xBT. Both these headphones stood out from the rest of the headphones that we had tested. The main reason is their positioning in the market. So when the M50xBT2 came to the test centre, I tested out all the changes between the ATH-M50xBT and the ATH-M50xBT2 and also compared them to the ATH-M20xBT to see how much of a difference approximately ₹10,000 brings in. Here's what I found out –

BUILD AND DESIGN

The overall design of the ATH-M50xBT2 is pretty much the same as its predecessor. The industrial design of these headphones is my and my lead reviewer, Dhriti's favourite. The biggest changes are in terms of the controls of the headphones. In the ATH-M50xBT, you had a toggle switch for power, while on the ATH-M50xBT2, it has been replaced with a regular button. The brand has added a dedicated voice assistant button to the control cluster. The micro-USB charging port has been swapped out for a more convenient and better USB-C port. And the branding on the headband was printed on in the earlier variation of the headphones, and in the ATH-M50xBT2, it is embossed.

The weight of the two devices remains the same, but I noticed the newer ATH-M50xBT2 had a more snug fit on my head. My head size is slightly on the larger side, so finding a pair of headphones that sits well on my head without crushing my skull is a bit of

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a task for me always. But with these, I got the perfect fit that I desired. I daily drive the ATH-M50xBT, and when I switched out to the ATH-M50xBT2, I barely noticed any difference apart from the clamping force.

When I wore it for long hours, like through an entire work day, taking calls, I experienced slight discomfort around my temple as the higher clamping force meant that the stem of my eye-glasses dug in. As we have mentioned numerous times before, the fit is completely subjective, and what works or might not work for me is totally different from what you'd get.

As for the materials, the plastic used is robust, and barely grabbed any scuffs or scratches while I was using the headphones. The headband has a metallic band layered over a plastic one, which makes it indestructible in daily use.

The cushioning is soft and comfortable, as usual. While on the topic of cushioning, over the three years that the ATH-M50xBT has been here in the Digit Test Centre, the leatherette material used on the headbands and the earcups has frayed. So, that is something you should keep in mind. The swivel mechanism on the headphones is robust as usual and ensures that the headphones can be worn the way you want to, and you get a great seal around your ears at all times. The USB-C and 3.5mm ports are robust, and the cables sit in place without moving much.

FEATURES

Like the ATH-M20xBT and others in the ATH-M BT lineup of headphones, the ATH-M50xBT2 is also not heavy on features. You get Google Fast Pair support, which works like a charm on Android devices. The controls are intuitive and easy to use. The button presses have a nice tactile feel to them, and every press is registered without any lag, regardless of the device I was connected to. When you plug in the 3.5 mm cable supplied with the headphones, they automatically turn off and switch to AUX mode, which is something I have loved on headphones!

There is multi-point connection support. The support for voice assistants has been added to the ATH-M50xBT2, which was missing on the cheaper ATH-M20xBT. Between my Apple iPhone 12 Mini and the test phone which I was using, the Google Pixel 6A, the voice assistant trigger and the voice command pickup were flawless for the most part. As for the app, it is also something extra that you get over the M20xBT with the ATH-M50xBT. The app is well done, with the design and flow being easy to navigate. The included penta band EQ should be good enough for most people to tune the sound signature of these headphones to their liking. And, that is about it. More massy headphones tend to have a more feature-rich app. But, these headphones do not have enough features only to be added to the app. Whatever is there though, is well